

**The Calling of Marriage**  
**A Biblical Analysis**  
by Preston Graham, Jr.

**Introduction:**

It needs to be said again, due in part to the apparent weakening of the marriage institution in our society, that marriage between a man and women IS a good thing! This is aptly summed up as God's wisdom in Proverbs 18:22, *The One who finds a spouse, finds a good thing, and gains favor from the Lord.*

But of course, the reality is that although marriage finds favor with God, marriage in a fallen context is NOT easy-- and what *calling* is? I'm reminded of something Martin Luther once confessed about marriage when he bluntly stated, "the *annoyances of married life are unbearable.*" And Luther's marriage to Katie is well known for its happiness and productivity even! It is likewise credited to Socrates that he once advised a young person who inquired about whether or not to be married, "*Whatever you may do, you will regret it.*"

To be sure, even happy and good marriages will to varying degrees struggle, especially within a cultural context such as our own where selfish and expressive individualism becomes the carrier of all types of marital diseases. Therefore, not only do we need to rediscover that marriage is a *good* thing, we need to rediscover that marriage is a sacred *calling* such as to inspire and require both a renewed sense of passion for it and a sacrificial devotion toward preserving it.

And if only for the sake of preserving the sanctity of marriage, we must likewise acknowledge that the power of marriage to bless is equaled only by its power to "curse." E.g. At what point does marital idolatry and abuse so escalate as to in effect annul it according to the Bible. And if but only to preserve marriage as an institution, not to mention to protect an innocent party in need of civil protections in an abusive marriage, we need to consider the biblical grounds for divorce as well.

Therefore, the intended purpose of this paper is two-fold:

- ✓ First, in so far as marriage is a *calling*, I will offer a brief rationale as to the sanctity and purpose of marriage (Part 1.I), together with a brief description as to the Biblical concession for divorce meant to protect marriage as an institution together with to protect "innocent" parties from marital abuse (Part 1.II).
- ✓ Second, in so far as marriage is the union of two sinners, I will offer some preliminary advice on how to find healing in a broken marriage (Part 1.2) together with recommend a process for discerning whether or not there are Biblical grounds for marital annulment upon the tragic condition that one partner has the right to the civil protections of the state in legal divorce, as recognized by the church, in order to be protected from a partner who has so violated the marriage covenant as to in effect annul it already (Part 2.2).

**Part One:**  
**The Sacred Institution of Marriage and Biblical Grounds for Divorce**

**I. The Sacred Institution of Marriage**

Although God does not call everyone to marriage (1Cor.7:8), when He does, it is a calling that assumes a sacred prominence before God as to enjoy his blessing and to inspire our utmost devotion. That is to say that the calling to marry is first and foremost a calling to the ideals of an institution rather than to whatever personal goals and dreams we may bring to a given marriage. A "calling" assumes of course that there is something about marriage which quite frankly transcends us as persons, much like say the calling to become a civil servant in government is more defined by the ideas of that government than whatever personal ambitions and satisfaction one may have in entering civil service. This is no less true for a calling to the ecclesial ministry, even as it is true for marriage. In other words, we need to think about "getting married" not only as related to "me" but as related to "it"—the marriage institution as for the common good even and ultimate for the glory of God.

The institutional framework for rediscovering the "call" to marriage is clearly established in Genesis 2 and related to two specific conclusions. First, it is the conclusion of scripture as from the redemptive historical inception of marriage that the institution of marriage itself be considered as God's idea, as then divinely appointed for humanity after a sacred purpose. It was God who declared "it is not good that the man should be alone" (Ge.2:18) even as it was God who brought the first wife to the first husband (Gen.2:22). Second, it is the conclusion of scripture as from the inception of marriage that the selection of a marriage partner itself, after all is said and done from a human vantage point, is ultimately considered as divinely decreed such that once a person is married, the Biblical assumption is that one is to remain in that marriage till "death do us part," except under the limited conditions that are recognized by God as a concession to preserving marriage itself together with an "innocent person" from marital abuse. Again, it was God who in prototypical fashion made a "helper suitable (or perhaps better "a complementary fit") for Adam, such that forever it is assumed that when it comes to marriage, once one is married to another, then each is considered in hindsight as from the vantage point of God's special decree and perfect selection.

In sum, both marriage as an institution and, once married, a specific marriage partners, is considered within the framework of Genesis 2 as "God's perfect idea." As then predicated upon this institutional framework the resulting devotion is clearly articulated in Gen.2:24, when in the language of a sacred vow, we read *For this cause a man shall leave father and mother, and shall cleave to his wife, and the two shall become one.* As then declared by Christ Himself about marriage, *what God has joined together, let no person separate* (Mt. 19:6).

Therefore, in so far as marriage is God's idea, it is the kind of thing someone enters into as a calling, which then is why we take vows to uphold it in the presence of many witnesses, not least of which is the witness of God himself according to Scripture. All such vows to sacred callings, no less the marriage vow, is something we should take only after due consideration. Again, in the words of God himself in holy scripture, *when you make a vow to God, do not delay fulfilling it; for he has no pleasure in fools. Fulfill what you vow. It is better that you should not vow than that you should vow and not fulfill it* (Eccl. 5:4-5).

According then to this general introduction to the sacred institution of marriage as instituted by God himself, the obvious question that all of this raises is "why is marriage so sacred?" E.g .What was meant by God for marriage to accomplish? What is it's purpose?

### **A. The Sacredness of Marriage Explained:**

Biblically, there are at least three defining dynamics of the marriage institution that render it sacred to God.

**First, there is a *imago dei* (image of God) dynamic that is uniquely expressed through marriage.**

*Gen.1:26, So God created humans in His image, in the image of God He created them male and female he created them.*

There is a revelatory aspect to marriage, in so far as the gender of male and female are both intrinsic to God *as one God*, even as this is reflected in the marriage of a man and women who are *as one person*. This is to say that humanity was created male and female *in relationship AS UNIQUELY expressed in marriage*. There is of course a mystery here, one that affirms femininity as derived from God, but not as to diminish the headship role of God as expressed in the role of husband/father such that the Bible will refer to God in the masculine. Rather the point here is simply to recognize that whatever roles are then given to humanity to fulfill, in so far as these roles are meant to be a reflection of who God is, then marriage between a man and a woman is absolutely necessary. Therefore, the image reflected in two distinct sexes was meant to draw man and woman together, as per Genesis 2:18, "It is not good for man to be alone; I will make him a helper suitable for him." This word "suitable" can be translated "compliment" or "matching" as to reflect that humanity, as a divine image, is incomplete apart from the two sexes acting in union through marriage. This then is also applied to both the vocational calling of God acting in humanity and the redemptive calling of God acting in humanity as per the second and third marriage dynamics that follow.

**Second, there is a vocational dynamic that is uniquely expressed through marriage.**

*Gen.1:28, God blessed them and God said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth and subdue it, and have dominion over the fish..*

Following the logic of the first dynamic in marriage, the "vocational" dynamic that is given to humanity (vs. 28) is stated after the relationship of man and women in marriage is established (26-27). There is then a vocational aspect to marriage, in so far as there is a "work" to be done for the glory of God and the benefit of humanity that is accomplished by the complementariness of husband and wife working together. This is not only satisfied in the procreation aspects of the mandate, but also in so far as the family becomes the institutional "germ seed" for both the historical development of the church and state in Biblical history. It can be said that the grace and law aspects of the church and state respectively require that which can be given ideally through the family as formed out of the marriage of husband and wife. As once noted by Samuel Davies,

The great Author of our nature, who has made us sociable creatures, has instituted various societies among mankind, both civil and religious, and joined them together by the various bonds of relation. The first and radical society is that of a family, which is the nursery of the church and state. This was the society instituted in paradise in the state of innocence, when the indulgent Creator, finding that it was not good for a man, a sociable creature, to be alone, formed a helpmeet for him and united them in the endearing bonds of the conjugal relation. From thence, the human race was propagated; and when multiplied, it was formed into civil governments and ecclesiastical assemblies...

Therefore, in so far as the family is the mother of all social institutions in our society, one can rightly say that so goes the family, so goes the health and well being of a civilization! IT IS A BIG DEAL and with far reaching implications that families are generated and preserved, as by the vows taken to initiate a family witnessed even by God!

### Third there is a redemptive dynamic that is uniquely expressed through marriage.

**Gen.2:24**, "For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two will become one flesh."

The apostle Paul leaves no doubt as to the ultimate meaning of this statement, when after quoting this passage in Eph. 5:31, he declares in verse 32, *This is a great mystery, and I am applying it to Christ and the church*. The context of this statement is of course Paul's exhortations to husbands and wives concerning their sacred roles one to the other—roles that are again envisioned from the very beginning of the marriage institution, albeit in germ seed fashion.

#### **Gen. 2:18**

Then the LORD God said, "It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him a helper as his partner..." **22** And the rib that the LORD God had taken from the man he made into a woman and brought her to the man.

As then to the ultimate vocation given to marriage, the scriptures portray the union of husband and wife in terms of a sacred and typological "role-play." This role-play is vaguely alluded to at creation when Adam was established first in the order of creation, followed then by the creation of women as a helper that was then "brought to" him. E.g. While it needs to be said that the woman is created "co-equal" as in the likeness of God, her role was in a subordinate capacity as to help Adam, even as she was brought to Adam as noted in 1Tim.2:13 to this effect. The purpose of this role-play is later exposed when after the fall and God's subsequent promise to bring forth redemption by the seed of a woman, Adam exercises his authority in naming her "Eve" or "mother of life" in so far as this expressed the redemptive promise to be accomplished by God as initiated by the birth of Seth and ultimately in the birth of Christ by the "seed of a woman" by miraculous conception.

Therefore, throughout redemptive history under both the Old and New Covenants, marriage is used as an analogy of God's covenant relationship with his church, a living paradigm depicting the redemptive relationship between God and his bride-people.<sup>1</sup> Marriage was considered "sacred" in its redemptive function meant to point people to God's plan of salvation. The dramatic role-play climaxes at the marriage of Christ to the church in salvation as gloriously described in Revelations 21:6-7.

Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns. Let us rejoice and be glad and give him the glory, for the marriage of the Lamb has come, and his bride has made herself ready; and to her it has been granted to be clothed with fine linen, bright and pure"-- for the fine linen is the righteous judgments on her behalf, And the angel said to me, "Write this: Blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb."

So then, when the congregation stands to give homage to the glory of a bride, beautifully adorned, in her procession to her eagerly awaiting groom, so we give homage to what transcends all of this in the procession of Christ church down through history to the loving embrace of her savior and husband Jesus Christ. The role-play has nothing at all to do with anything intrinsic to maleness or femaleness, at least in so far as the scripture is concerned, but as related to the order of creation that establishes a typological relationship between a husband and wife that is to direct their roles for the sake of bearing witness to Christ and

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<sup>1</sup> Hosea 2:18-20, Ezekiel 16:8, Mt. 19:4-6, 1 Cor. 11:3, Eph. 5:22-24

His bride, the church. Even as Jesus Christ himself cloths his bride with the unconditional love and righteous works given to the church for her sanctification before God and received by faith alone so too the husband is commanded to love his wife as Christ loved the church, even giving himself to her as to sanctify her (typologically) by his righteous deeds on her behalf, even as the wife is commanded to submit herself to her husband as unto the Lord, receiving his leadership and sacrificial love as to role play the faith of the church to Christ (see then Ephesians 5:22ff). In summary, we should notice how Paul explicitly applies Genesis The whole thing is sacred in so far as it uniquely expresses and dramatically gives witness to the salvation plan of God.

### Addendum: On “co-equality of gender within marriage”

As per the above, we want to affirm the scriptures teaching that women and men are co-equals in their office of the *imago dei* and *Christian believer* and therefore share in the privileges and responsibilities that are related to each as per the social and managerial “system” within the home.

Again, that the *imago dei* is both “male and female” is made explicit in Genesis 1:26-27. Of women, it is said that she is a “helper *comparable* to” the man (Gen.2:18).<sup>2</sup> Subsequently, through the course of redemptive history women are not subordinated to men in so far as their creation status is concerned, even as this was worked out vocationally in society at large. To say otherwise would surely diminish the economic and even political roles that women had for the sake of her households as depicted say in Proverbs 31.<sup>3</sup> And both the female tentmaker Priscilla and the wealthy and cosmopolitan businesswoman Lydia placed their homes and assets at the disposal of Paul and other preachers. They did this as those who were providentially authorized by God to do so as they used their *worldly* vocations to serve the kingdom of God.<sup>4</sup> Lydia especially was a woman of international renown and evidently the head of a sizable household as a single women, and yet nowhere is her social status that would have placed her on an equal footing with men in her business dealings disparaged in scripture.<sup>5</sup>

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<sup>2</sup> Literally, the Hebrew word *ḥēn* can mean “in the sight of”, “in front of” even “opposite to.” In Gen. 2:18, it is used with the preposition “like to, as.” The compound phrase “opposite him” refers then to a “matching” kind of relationship. Therefore, some translations have interpreted this as related to the complementarity of women to men, such as the ESV “fit to” or, as noted in the ESV, “corresponding to.” Perhaps more insightful than a strict word study even is its use in context, especially vs. 20 of chapter 2, where it is used to describe the women in relation to man in context with his vocational role of exercising authority over creation in naming them. (which in the ancient Near East was an exercise of authority). The man was in some sense “inadequate” to accomplish the task such as to require a “helper.” The point here is merely to say that the women, was created to “help” Adam in his vocational activity, not to merely benefit from his vocational activity. Vocational speaking, the text gives no indication that women were not actively involved in a capacity “comparable” to man in the creation mandate.

<sup>3</sup> Likewise, there is no indication in the text that Deborah was breaking a law (or that God was suspending a law) when she assumed the judgeship (“presidency”) of Israel in Judges 4

<sup>4</sup> Acts 16:14,15,40 & 18:2-26.

<sup>5</sup> As from Acts 16:13ff, Lydia was a wealthy business woman from Asia who traveled to one the great commercial cities of that day, Phillippi. In today’s terms, she could be described as an upper-class and cosmopolitan style business woman. That she was wealthy is clear by the fact that she had a large enough house to accommodate the four missionaries in addition to her own household... which would have most likely included several servants. Even in that day, a woman with a large household (4-5 children) were given legal privileges to transact business in the market. Her trade was in fine and expensive garments that were treated with an expensive purple dye from a Thyatiran manufacturer in her home region. Her name Lydia, was probably not her personal name but her trade name—given that both she and her trade was from the Asian context of the ancient kingdom of Lydia. Thus, “the Lydian lady”... (see Stott, *The Message of Acts*)

The implication of this first principle is that “roles” within the home, or elsewhere, are nowhere distinguished in scripture, EXCEPT in so far as for the redemptive typology or “role-play” noted already. While it may be expedient and wise to devise a system of labor distribution and cooperatives within the home, it is NOT the case that one gender is necessarily assigned to any one responsibility. For example, it is no more the inherent “calling” of women to wash the dishes as it is the inherent calling for men to take out the trash—both are what I like to call the “grunt” jobs of household management that must be done—how any one marriage chooses to “divide and conquer” in a way that in the overall scheme expresses a kind of vocational mutuality relative to the home management is purely a matter to be discerned according to the “system” aspects of a given family. Ordinarily, the principle driving job distribution would be driven by 1) mutuality and fairness in terms of overall work load both in and out of the home and 2) giftedness and ability in terms of who is best fit the task.

The point then is this—whereas it may or may not fall to any one spouse to do such and such task, if it does, it isn’t because the “bible says so.” Marriage couples ought to be driven by the principle of “co-equality” and therefore “co-responsibility” as per the household economy and management relative to the whole vocational system at a given phase of life. In the case where one spouse is working more hours “outside of the home” than another, this of course may necessitate that the other spouse do more work “within the home,” but not because it is the biblical responsibility of any one spouses role to work within the home as much as it is both the husband and wife’s role to work ‘for the home’ and the overall calling that God has for that home for his glory, however this works out by way of distribution in God’s providence.<sup>6</sup>

Likewise and secondly, in the new creation of God as through faith in Jesus Christ, Paul declares that “there is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, *male nor female*, for you are all one in Christ Jesus.”<sup>7</sup> Therefore, in so far as giftedness for the church is concerned, Nigel Lee comments how “all female Christians too are ‘heirs together’ with all of their Christian brothers, and are themselves to be Christ’s prophetesses and priestesses and queens – all the time (as being “in Christ”).<sup>8</sup> In short, all Christian persons are set apart in their Christian baptism to the “office” of believer with corresponding gifts that are beneficial to the body of Christ.<sup>9</sup> There are no gender-related qualifications attached to the gifts listed by Paul in Romans 12:1-5!

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<sup>6</sup> Some have understandably wondered about the meaning “workers at home” (NASB version) in Titus 2:5.

The Greek word οἰκουρργοὺς has also been translated “managers of the home” (NRSV). There is, to be sure, a whole range of possible meanings for this word—as per putting together the idea of “home/household” and “work/devotion/energy” etc. Regardless of cultural differences in a pre-modern compared to a modern/post-modern economy and sociology, Paul’s point is that older women are to teach younger women to be active in their callings as per their home vs. being lazy and or “busy bodies (see context) as per their. That is pretty much Paul’s only point—not that for women to do this they must necessarily do this or that task or serve in this or that capacity relative to within or without the home. Yes, women are to be committed to being a godly wife and mother, even as this pertains to her life management for the sake of her home, but this doesn’t then speak to the issue of proper ways of delegating, hiring, job distribution as per the needs of a given family.. How then this plays out given our social and economic context today is again subject to the wise discretion of the wife and husband together

<sup>7</sup> Gal.3:28

<sup>8</sup> I Pet. 3:7 cf. I Cor. 10:51 & Eccl. 3:1-13 & 5:18-20 & 9:7-10. Cf. also F.N. Lee’s 1977 Principles of Biblical Church Government, and especially the section there on The Office of All Believers. Indeed, every human being should be involved in serving God as a “minister” alias a “servant” of the Lord. Rom, 13:4 cf, I Tim, 1:12 & I Pet, 4:10-11.

<sup>9</sup> Cf. Matt. 28:19 & Acts. 8:12 Ex.19:3-8 & Num, 11:29 & Joel 2:16,28-29 & Acts 2:17,38-39 & I Cor. 12:13-20,26 & Gal. 3:27-28 & Eph, 4:4-5,12-13,16 & I Pet, 2:9, So also Martin Luther, the Belgic Confession, the Heidelberg Catechism, the Westminster Confession of Faith, and especially the Westminster Larger Catechism # 167.

Again, the implication of this second principle is that there is nothing inherent to the role of "husband and wife" that require the either to be the "teacher," "conversational initiator," etc. Spiritual authority and leadership is one thing, having abilities to teach or outgoing personalities is an altogether other thing. Well meaning Christians have perhaps made some significant errors at this point in my opinion. It is NOT the biblical "role" of women to wait for a husband to bring issues up, any more than it is her biblical role to not offer her opinions and "argued" in a persuasive way. To be sure, the role-play is such that the husband will want to insure that the wife's best interest is considered as per the family dynamic, even as the wife will want to insure that the husband's office as the spiritual "head" of the home is respected, resulting then in a willingness to defer to the husband's leadership if needed. But ordinarily, decisions are best made by forming a consensus, and when a consensus cannot be formed and a decision must be made, the husband is wise to defer to his wife in such cases where the wife is the one who providentially is responsible for the execution of a given sphere of responsibility or duty. In short, it is as much the prerogative, even duty, for the wife to initiate needed conversations, prayers, teachings in the bible, etc. as it is the prerogative and duty of the man acting out of their office of "Christian believer." In sum, there is no reason to doubt that the "one another" clauses of say Col. 2:12ff apply to men and women equally.

In short, both men and women, acting in "the image of God" are co-equal partners in the cultural and cultic mandate given at creation as related to the dual command to "tend" and "guard" the creation-temple of God respectively.<sup>10</sup>

## **B. The Sacredness of Marriage Affirmed:**

The above survey regarding the purpose of marriage is admittedly theo-centric, not such as to diminish the potential and corresponding blessing of marriage for a specific couple no less than for society at large as per Proverbs 18:22. But it should be observed all the same that marriage, even as it serves humanity, derives its ultimate importance in its service to the glory of God as both Creator and Redeemer! There is, to say it plainly, some things about marriage that transcend and even usurp whatever personal happiness or suffering that a particular marriage may or may not attain. This is perfectly acknowledged in the classic and familiar marriage vow, "for better or for worse, for richer or for poor, in sickness and in health." This language is essentially the same as a vow of poverty, at least potentially, as to a calling that exceeds the individual's self interest. In other words, marriage as a calling, is ultimately less about us and more about God. We enter into marriage the way one enters into other such "callings" wherein it is recognized that one is committing oneself to a "noble dream" that is intrinsic to the institution we are called to serve less anything about us. Just as say the value of the office of elder/pastor, civil servant or educator exceeds the person holding it for the good of God's special or common grace for his ultimate glory, so too, the office of husband and wife exceeds the persons that hold them for the good of God's self revelation and plan of salvation. Every authentic calling has a noble dream that makes whatever sacrifices and sufferings that may occur as a cost worthy of the calling! And so

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<sup>10</sup> See for instance Meredith Kline's, *Kingdom Prologue*, (Two Age Press, 2000) p. 68ff. He states "an institutional union was effected between the first man and woman by marriage ordinance. They were of course one in generic classification as members of one of the "kinds" God created. They were male and female varieties of man-"kind", each individually a members of the image of God "kind" (Gen.1:27)... it was within this marital relationship of legal troth that the procreation function of the cultural commission was to be fulfilled... the goal in view was the city of the royal human family, filling and ruling the earth." The subordination of women to man as also indicated in Genesis if by the naming of Eve by Adam alone, is not however viewed as being violated when the women participates with the man in the cultural mandate. Therefore, as Kline further notes, "man" (speaking of humanity) was commissioned to enter into and carry forward the work of God... God's work was creative, sustaining, governing; so too, on a creaturely level, was man's."

we add to our classic vow, "until death do us part" or "whatever it takes to accomplish God's self revelation and plan of salvation in this marriage, I commit myself to it until I die." So then, when a person decides to get married, their decision is to the institution itself, more so than to any particular desire one has for ones self in marriage. The duties of marriage are to "love" and "respect" for the glory of God, less to self-love and self-respect even. Again, the decision is less—will this person satisfy my needs such as to make the person an idol, and more "is this a person that I can love and respect such as together we can satisfy the sacred calling of marriage for the glory of God!

Consider then the covenantal language that is applied to marriage as fitting a sacred calling, both stated in positive and negative ways throughout scripture.

As to the positive ways God affirms the sacredness of marriage from the very beginning, as then affirmed by Christ himself:

1. In Genesis, notice the language of *cleave*:

Genesis 2:18, *And the Lord said, "It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him a helper as his partner... Therefore, a man leaves his father and his mother and cleaves to his wife, and they become one flesh.*

It is important to see the covenantal language in this word! This is not just descriptive language, but also language that places this relationship into a covenant context of binding vows! For instance, when Scripture says that a man shall "cleave" to his wife (Gen.2:24), it is using a covenant term used elsewhere to express the way the Israelites were to cleave with affection and loyalty to the Lord. (Dt.10:20, 11:22, 13:4, Josh.22:5, etc.) To "cleave" is to be joined to another in a way that assumes the interest of the other as forever my interest. It is something of what Paul meant when he says in Eph. 5:28 *In the same way, husbands should love their wives as they do their own bodies. He who loves his wife loves himself.*

2. Notice again in Genesis the language *bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh* (Gen. 2:23).

Again, when Adam made his solemn affirmation that "this is now bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh" it was not some inane observation as if God needed to be informed concerning Eve's origins. Rather these words constituted a solemn oath of covenant faithfulness-- an abbreviated way of saying "may this woman be to me as my own body-- and because of this, should I ever fail to love and care for her as my own body, thereby breaking the covenant bond between us, I hereby solemnly invite God to make it hurt me like bones and flesh being wrenched out of my body." That this statement was a covenantal oath is further demonstrated by the use of the phrase "bone of my bones" in other similar oath taking ceremonies in the Ancient Near East as depicted in Genesis 29:14. (See also the use of this formula in Judges 9:2, 2 Samuel 19:12-13) This formula then informs the NT teaching that husband are to love their wives as their own bodies. (Eph.5:21-33)

3. The covenantal aspect of this original language is again recognized by Christ when in response to the Pharisees attempt at undermining the marriage institution, he affirmed:

**Mt. 4-6a** "Have you not read that the one who made them at the beginning 'made them male and female,' 5 and said, 'For this reason a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh'? 6 So they are no longer two, but one flesh.

Stated then negatively, God also expresses his mind on the subject of divorce, as related to



the sacred vows of marriage.

1. Again, in Malachi we see the covenantal language explicitly references as then applied to God's disdain for divorce.

*Mal. 2:14 You ask, "Why does he not?" Because the LORD was a witness between you and the wife of your youth, to whom you have been faithless, though she is your companion and your wife by covenant. 15 Did not one God make her? Both flesh and spirit are his. And what does the one God desire? Godly offspring. So look to yourselves, and do not let anyone be faithless to the wife of his youth. 16 For I **hate divorce**, says the LORD, the God of Israel, and covering one's garment with violence, says the LORD of hosts. So take heed to yourselves and do not be faithless.*

As is true for all covenant makings, there is always the taking of vows in the presence of witnesses. In this case, the vow of the marriage covenant is said to be witnessed by God himself. The covenantal aspect of marriage is often used in Scripture as an analogy of God's covenant relationship with Israel and in the New Testament of Christ's relationship with the Church. Marriage served to provide people with a living paradigm depicting the redemptive relationship between God and his bride-people. (Hosea 2:19-20, Ezekiel 16:8, Ephesians 5:21-33, Matthew 19:4-6) Like the divine-human covenantal relationship, the marriage covenant between man and woman was intended by God to be loving, loyal and permanent.<sup>11</sup>

2. Christ also warns those who would weaken and annul the marriage covenant.

Mt. 6b-9:

Therefore what God has joined together, let no one separate." They said to him, "Why then did Moses command us to give a certificate of dismissal and to divorce her?" He said to them, "It was because you were so hard-hearted that Moses allowed you to divorce your wives, but from the beginning it was not so. And I say to you, whoever divorces his wife, except for fornication, and marries another commits adultery.

Again, Matthew 19:1-9, both the original design of marriage and its covenantal nature is recounted by Christ in response to the then popular laxity with respect to divorce. Christ's point, in vs. 4 is to reiterate that *what God has joined together, let no one separate*. As will be explained below, Christ's only provision for giving a certificate of divorce is when in effect an innocent party as been in effect divorced already.

### C. Sexuality and Marriage:

Before moving to the next issue of divorce, it is important to at least briefly put all of this into the context of sexual oneness in marriage, even as this will be a central topic when talking about divorce as well. As per the covenantal language of Genesis 2:18, while "one flesh" is clearly not reduced to simply "having sex" it clearly envisions sex as somehow related to marital oneness. E.g. the complimentary aspects of marriage in the *imago dei*, the calling to be "as one" in vocation and even the mystery of Christ in communion with the church are all three expressed in the covenant "ritual" of sex between married partners.

By way of analogy, sex is to marriage what the sacraments are to the church. Even as a

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<sup>11</sup> Far from just hearing in Malachi some terrifying harshness in our Lord regarding divorce, we should be glad that God hates divorce. For Him to hate divorce is to declare in the starkest possible way that He is on our side when marriage gets difficult-- a glorious message of hope for troubled marriages. He stands ready to help his children avoid what He hates.

sacrament both *symbolizes* AND actually *executes* or “*effects*” God’s gracious covenant with his people, so too sex in marriage is both *symbolic* and *efficacious* in nature. To be sure, in its *symbolic* aspects, there is a “fit” physically that is meant to depict the “fit” relative to the female/male aspects of the sacred call to marriage.<sup>12</sup> Therefore, just as Paul will speak of not being bound to idols in 1 Cor. 10 as related then to the meaning of the Lord’s supper, so too he uses similar language to describe the sin of fornication in so far as “marriage” is meant to typologize Christ in covenant with the church. E.g.

*1 Cor. 15 Do you not know that your bodies are members of Christ? Should I therefore take the members of Christ and make them members of a prostitute? Never! 16 Do you not know that whoever is united to a prostitute becomes one body with her? For it is said, “The two shall be one flesh.” 17 But anyone united to the Lord becomes one spirit with him. 18 Shun fornication!*

Moreover, in its *efficacious* aspects, there is likewise both a covenant *initiation* and covenant *renewal* dynamic to the sacraments that is also according to scripture expressed in marital sexuality. So for instance, the centrality of sexual union for marriage is especially illustrated by Scripture in cases where sexual union is shown to obligate marriage except in cases where the Father of the woman refuses to give his daughter to the man (Exodus 22:16ff, Dt.22:28-29). Even betrothal (what we describe as “engaged to be married”) is a pledge of cleaving such that a betrothed woman is called a man’s wife (Gen.29:21, Dt.22:23-24, Mt.1:18-24).<sup>13</sup> One could say that sexual union both obligates and consummate marriage. So also, sexual union in marriage both promotes loving loyalty and is the result of loving loyalty, even as it is often the case that one partner will tend to lean toward one or the other effect.

The point is this-- one can properly say that sexual union IS marriage, even if there is more to marriage than sex of course! Sexual union is representative of the unity and sacred complementariness that is accomplished by covenant love in marriage. Sexual union also serves to effect the unity and sacred complementariness as well. It should be said as well that one of the sad realities of sin in the world is that the use of God’s creation is idolized such that we either abuse God’s gifts (materialism) or we abstain from God’s gifts (asceticism). A materialistic or ascetic view of sex are both the byproducts of idolizing sex in our society and can wreak havoc on the otherwise beauty of sex in marriage. To be sure, the “romance” of God, even as expressed in God’s love for his church is perfectly, albeit typological, expressed in the ritual of sex in marriage. It is right and part of God’s plan for marriage couples to long for one another romantically/sexually, even as this is poetically depicted in the *Song of Solomon*. However, this longing must not be reduced to mere self-love. It is rather the longing of love to then consummate that love in giving oneself to another. To be sure, there is an overall parity in mutuality that is to be expressed in sex that is perfectly suited to the life long pursuit of covenant fidelity in marriage. Sexuality therefore is important and includes all things pertaining to becoming one flesh as within the unconditional and covenantal love between marriage partners. All this then to say that the valid contraction of marriage is sexual union whereby the “two become one flesh.”

Accordingly Paul makes it clear that sexuality in marriage is NOT to be controlled by any one partner against the other. Quite the contrary, Paul’s counsel is that each marriage partner is to give freely and unconditionally themselves, and yes, this includes their sexuality, to the

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<sup>12</sup> Perhaps more so than “proof-texting” its then the logic of marriage as related to its three sacred purposes that speak against even monogamous homosexuality as satisfying the sacred intent for the marriage institution.

<sup>13</sup> For the record, I take 1 Thess.4:4-5, Lev.19:20-22, Dt.21:10-14, to mean that betrothal should precede sexual union.

other, except by way of mutual agreement for the sake of spiritual renewal in an extended season of prayer. Paul says it this way:

**1 Cor. 7:3** The husband should give to his wife her conjugal rights, and likewise the wife to her husband. **4** For the wife does not have authority over her own body, but the husband does; likewise the husband does not have authority over his own body, but the wife does. **5** Do not deprive one another except perhaps by agreement for a set time, to devote yourselves to prayer, and then come together again,

### **Part 1.1 Summary:**

Such then is the sacredness of marriage both explained and affirmed by Scripture, as then beautifully expressed and actualized in sexual oneness. With such high regards for the marriage institutions, one wonders that there could be any grounds for divorce as recognized by God. We must therefore turn our attention to the subject of divorce more directly, as to when God recognizes one right to get a divorce, before then moving to some advice all of this brings relative to those struggling in their marriage and then the recommended procedure for seeking a divorce.

## **II. Biblical Grounds for Divorce:**

It should be stated clearly, that no where does God “proscribe” divorce in scripture. Rather, God does “recognize” it such then to recognize the need for an *innocent* party to seek civil and ecclesiastical protection in such case as they have already, in effect, been divorced. E.g. The logic that will be presented here is that marriage is sacred, and should never be annulled. But as a provision to the reality of sin in the world, it is recognized that some will be bound to a person who has in fact already annulled the marriage by his/her actions such as to warrant the procurement of their civil rights as a person made in God’s image as with the ecclesial rights of those who belong to Christ and have rights to his mediated grace through the church. What followed therefore is an explanation of this from scripture.

### **A. God allows for divorce by way of a reluctant provision so as to restrain evil against innocent parties. (Matthew 19:3-9, Mark 10:2-11)**

*Matt. 19:3 Some Pharisees came to him, and to test him they asked, “Is it lawful for a man to divorce his wife for any cause?” 4 He answered, “Have you not read that the one who made them at the beginning ‘made them male and female,’ 5 and said, ‘For this reason a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh’? 6 So they are no longer two, but one flesh. Therefore what God has joined together, let no one separate.” 7 They said to him, “Why then did Moses command us to give a certificate of dismissal and to divorce her?” 8 He said to them, “It was because you were so hard-hearted that Moses allowed you to divorce your wives, but from the beginning it was not so. 9 And I say to you, whoever divorces his wife, except for fornication, and marries another commits adultery.”*

### **Observations:**

a. Divorce is NOT instituted by God, only sadly recognized as then to demand legal protections in some limited cases.

E.g, In Dt.22:19-20, 24:1-4,, Lev.21:7, 14; 22:13 and Nu.30:9, the Mosaic law takes the custom of divorce for granted, it does not institute divorce, but regulates it to limit and preclude its abuse. In cases where divorce is regulated in the OT, it is only applied specifically to cases involving sexual immorality. God allows divorce only as a common grace provision to restrain the evil of fornication (see explanation below)

against the righteous/innocent party.

b. As Christ clearly stated, it is only provisional in response to the *hardness of hearts*. (Mt. 19:8, Mark 10:5)

E.g. See also Matthew 5:32, Luke 16:18, 1 Cor.7: 10-11. Of course, all married couples are "guilty" of the sin of self-love and selfish ambition as to a "hardness of heart," which is of course why the gospel is such "good news." Here, Christ's statement is to acknowledge that divorce is necessary given the sad reality that this self-love and self-ambition can ultimately reach a point where actions are taken such as to annul the marriage albeit while the "innocent" party is still bound to the marriage. The question then is, "what behavior is so intrinsically antithetical to the marriage institution as to in effect annul it?"

**B. The limited condition for divorce allowed by God is stated by Christ as one--"fornication."**

**1. The Meaning of "fornication" (or Grk. πορνεία) as to include adultery.**

Mt. 19:9 *And I say to you, whoever divorces his wife, except for fornication...*

At the very least, "porneia" is to violate the monogamy aspect of the marriage in so far as to enter sexually into a marriage with another, even if not legally to annul the marriage, to then essentially and spiritually annul the marriage. This is why Christ then explains "porneia" as to imply the result that the guilty person in effect "marries another and commits adultery." Fornication (porneia) is used in scripture to describe acts that violate the sexual union between a man and a woman in marriage such that if married, the "innocent" party has grounds for divorce. He/she has the right to expect monogamy in marriage and the exclusive loyalty this demands as per the sacred role-play. In short, once adultery has occurred, the marriage itself has been annulled. This is not to say that the marriage is irreparable, but that in a legal sense under God's law, the innocent party has the right to a divorce. E.g. It is any act against sexual ("one flesh") union as per the "covenantal cleaving" in marriage.

**2. As to include desertion:**

1 Cor.7:2-15 teaches that "porneia" by inference includes desertion. E.g. We should notice carefully how in an impressive way, Paul first insists on sexual mutuality in marriage, such that to deny one's partner sex is apart from mutual consent is to in effect "desert" the marriage itself.

a. 1 Cor.7:5-6, *Do not deprive one another except perhaps by agreement for a set time to devote yourselves to prayer, and then come together again so that Satan may not tempt you.*

There is no "separation" recognized in Scripture apart from the legal, valid divorce or by mutual consent. The Greek term "separate" is used synonymously to mean "divorce." The "concession" Paul gives in 1 Cor.7:5-6 is the permission given for this extremely limited kind of separation for the brief period of concentrated prayer. Note then, how Paul phrases it in terms of a limited refraining from sexual union. Though often overlooked, it is crucial to see that "fornication" as a comprehensive term for sexual immorality does have for an attested

meaning a specific reference to willful desertion-- an explicitly sexual sin in that it entails the defrauding of a spouse conjugal rights.<sup>14</sup>

b. 1 Cor.7:15, *Yet if the unbelieving partner separates, let it be so, in such a case the brother or the sister is not bound.*

Paul is not adding here to the conditions of divorce specified by Christ's clarification of the Mosaic law regarding the limited conditions of fornication. Rather, Paul is merely demonstrating that desertion does in fact violate the "one flesh" union that is insisted upon in 1 Cor. 7:5-6. (see above) By way of extension of Christ's single condition for recognizing the divorce therefore, "porneia" is also committed when a one party "leaves" the other either by removing him/her self physically or perhaps behaving in a way that renders it essential by threat to life or health.

c. By good and necessary inference, it can be demonstrated that perhaps several other instances could likewise fall under Paul's understanding of "desertion" as a sub-category of fornication. For instance, since life precedes marriage, the marriage is therefore conditioned upon the viability of those living within it. Therefore, it can be argued that in such cases as spousal abuse, the innocent party has by necessity of life the need for separation. This separation would be a "desertion" category of fornication since the effect is that sexual union is prevented due to threat of life. Likewise, one could argue that perhaps a person who has violated the civil law so as to be put in jail, (justly) has likewise violated the "one flesh" contract in marriage so as to fulfill the conditions of fornication as in the case of desertion. Ultimately, whereas "adultery" is

### C. Relevant Church Standards regarding Marriage and Divorce:

WCF: 24: 5. Adultery or fornication committed after a contract, being detected before marriage, gives just occasion to the innocent party to dissolve that contract. In the case of adultery after marriage, it is lawful for the innocent party to sue out a divorce and, after the divorce, to marry another, as if the offending party were dead.

24:6. Although the corruption of man be such as is apt to study arguments unduly to put asunder those whom God has joined together in marriage: yet, nothing but adultery, or such wilful desertion as can no way be remedied by the Church, or civil magistrate, is cause sufficient of dissolving the bond of marriage: wherein, a public and orderly course of proceeding is to be observed; and the persons concerned in it not left to their own wills, and discretion, in their own case.

Notes: from PCA study report on "desertion"

p. 193—Perkin's—"But if one of them by just occasion of fear be compelled to depart from the other, and cannot return again without apparent danger of life..."

p. 199—report "we know him also to be a deserter who does not refuse cohabitation, but obstinately demands impious conditions... to depart from someone and to drive the other away by threats or force are the same thing." Theodore Beza

p. 200, Samuel Maresius—"by intolerable cruelty putting life at hazard for the present..."

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<sup>14</sup> See for examples, Judges 19:2 [note that the second clause is in apposition to the first], Exodus 21:10-11, Hosea 2:2 and Jeremiah 2:2-32 (the later two passages specifically single out the sin of Israel's desertion as an additional ground justifying God's contemplated "divorce" of His wife-people.

RPCES GA, May18, 1973

*Marriage is the unique one-flesh relationship of a man and woman joined together by God in a union that He wills to be both permanent and exclusive, binding the couple to each other in a life-long companionship of common life and conjugal love. (Gen.2:23-24, Mat.19:4-8)*

*It is the duty of husband and wife to maintain the unity and integrity of their marriage of cohabitation and coition. (LC, Q.138)*

BCO Chapter 59, "The Solemnization of Marriage"

(which is non-binding but all the same is an "approved guide and should be taken seriously as the mind of the church agreeable to the Standards")

-- nothing is said as to the issue of grounds for divorce, remarriage, etc. As noted above, it does speak to the issue of proper jurisdiction and the propriety of marriage being "solemnized" by a lawful minister, and issues related to this.

## **Part 1.2 Conclusion:**

- I. God views marriage as sacred, and desires that marriage be preserved and healed until such time as divorce is necessary for the protection of an innocent party.
- II. For the sake of both the sanctify of the marriage institution and the protection of the innocent, there are two grounds for divorce (some would say one ground with two expressions as per the above...)
  1. Adultery: When one partner gives him/herself emotionally AND sexually to another outside of marriage, is unwilling to repent and therefore while legally married, the marriage covenant has been in its essence annulled.
    - i. Note: If the guilty party does repent, the scriptures exhorts the innocent party to forgive and may, for the sake of the marriage institution itself, be willing to remain in the marriage, however it remains the prerogative of the innocent party to remain in the marriage or file for a divorce.
  2. Desertion: When one party is "abandoned" by another such that while perhaps "legally" "married" they are no longer married "functionally" in any real sense... I.e.
    - i. When one party physically leaves and is no longer committed to fulfilling their marriage vows of giving love and support... (not to be confused with when a party is physically absent due to a providentially necessary situation outside of their control...
    - ii. When one party threatens the life and health of another in some real and tangible way. E.g. not merely "sever emotional stress" but a condition where the first right of a person to physical life and health is maliciously threatened by another... e.g. physical abuse, or reasonable threat to such...
    - iii. When on party abandons the other both emotionally AND sexually. E.g. Unwilling to have sexual relations with partner.

## **Part 2:**

### **Scripture Advice for Troubled Marriages and Those Seeking A Divorce**

#### **I. Scriptural advice for those who have troubled marriages:**

1. There must first be a macro-reorientation concerning the nature of love in

## marriage.

Too often, the problem in marriages is TOO high of expectations concerning what marriage can and is meant to do. When we idolize marriage or the marriage partner, marriage becomes a means of self-love and self-gratification rather than a calling to love one another as a means of serving God and even society as a covenant institution. The result of creating an idol out of marriage and/or our marriage partner is to then "need" our marriage and or marriage partner for the sake of finding that which only God can give through Christ. If according to Augustine "our hearts are restless until they find their rest in God" it is too often the case that coupled get married thinking their restless hearts will find rest in a spouse—with tragic consequences. The result is a marriage characterized more by manipulation than ministry one to the other in order to satisfy our craving hearts than can only be satisfied by God. In short, to idolize marriage is to ignore the sacred purpose of marriage which is, ironically, to direct us to salvation as accomplished and applied by Christ, rather than to become our salvation, as so many pop love songs seem to suggest.

As noted then by Robert Bellah,

Marriage becomes a context for expressive individualism, or a "life style enclave... for in believing in love, we American's believe in the self. The love that must hold us together is rooted in the vicissitudes of our subjectivity.... Love is redefined as self-knowledge and self-realization

Biblical love is a commitment to another, fundamentally, and to doing what is for the good of my partner—regardless of its impact upon me even. Biblical love assumes that our own needs are met by Christ. Therefore, we are exhorted in Ephesians 5:1-2 as immediately followed by instructions regarding marital relations.

*Therefore be imitators of God, as beloved children, 2 and live in love, as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God...*

Note also that this passage indicates that acts of love are an obligation to God, and can be done regardless of emotion. In the unbiblical model, love is passive, it just happens. In the biblical model, love is active, it comes out of our volition in submission to God. This has been noted by Jay Adams in the following way:

*There is a widespread notion that romantic love is necessary to form a strong, biblical marriage. While nothing that I say must be understood to denigrate the idea of romantic love itself as pursued biblically, nevertheless, the idea that such love is ground for marriage is unbiblical... the Bible nowhere makes romantic love a ground or basis for marriage... Marriage is not based on an existing emotion, but on the promise that one will give love to his or her spouse throughout their lives together.*

(Jay Adams, p.30, Solving Marriage Problems)

## 2. Grace as prerequisite to happiness in marriage:

**Ephesians 4:22** *You were taught to put away your former way of life, your old self, corrupt and deluded by its lusts, 23 and to be renewed in the spirit of your minds, 24 and to clothe yourselves with the new self, created according to the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness. 25 So then, putting away falsehood... 29 Let no evil talk come out of your mouths, but only what is useful for building up, as there is need, so that your words may give grace to those who hear. 30 And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, with which you were marked with a seal for the day of redemption. 31 Put away from you all bitterness and wrath and anger and wrangling and slander, together with all malice, 32 and be kind to one another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, as God in Christ has forgiven you.*

### Observation:

Reconciliation and marital contentment is the product of two people being transformed by the power of the gospel. That is to say that the gospel is the prerequisite to fulfilling our calling in marriage, if not also to a happy marriage. And among other attributes that flows from the gospel, one of the foremost is the attribute of forgiveness-- a kind of forgiveness that is not determined by the "forgivability" of our partners, however conceived, but in the reality of our being forgiven by Christ. For it is true, that you will never be asked to forgive your partner, the amount of times, and with the same degree of offensiveness, that God has in Christ first forgiven you. Therefore, happy marriages are the result of two forgiven people. And forgiven people forgive others as they have been forgiven by Christ. Grace in marriage begins with an acceptance of the other person, even a commitment to love the other person where they most need love, which is where they are most prone to sin or most broken and weak. Even as Christ loved us even WHILE we were sinners, so too we ought to love our spouse as evidenced by acceptance and grace!

In sum, and as noted by Tim Keller:

"The gospel is not just the "A-B-C" but the "A-to-Z" of the Christian life. The gospel is not just the way to enter the kingdom, but is the way to address every problem and is the way to grow at every step. If we believe we can find our own worth and meaning through performance, then we will become either proud and disdainful of ourselves (if we reach our goals), or else discouraged and self-loathing (if we fail our goals). But the gospel creates an entirely new self-image.

First, it tells us that we are more wicked than we ever dared believe, but more loved and accepted in Christ than we ever dared to hope—at the same time. In fact, if the gospel is true, the *more* you see your sin, the more certain you are that you were saved by sheer grace and the more precious and electrifying that grace is to you. So the gospel gives us enormous power to admit our flaws.

Then secondly, the knowledge of our acceptance in Christ makes (for the first time) the law of God a beauty instead of a burden. We come to use it to delight the One who has enriched us so mightily—instead of using it to get his attention or win his favor. The first way makes the moral and sacrificial life a joy; the second way makes it a burden."

One needs only to apply the gospel to our "marriage" in the appropriate places to discover how the gospel can be a transforming power to fix a troubled marriage. As one person put it, "marriage is the union of two good forgivers." There is no forgiveness apart from the grace poured out in the gospel of Jesus Christ. Whether you are a Christian of many years or not, don't assume that you are experiencing the grace of the gospel because you merely understand the gospel in its basis tenants. This is the point of Ephesians 3:14-21. The power of godliness in love is proportionate to the degree in which our affections for Christ can sustain it, which in turn is proportionate to the degree to which we have experienced the power of God's love in us. In other words, we must experience the power of God's love in the gospel in order to love God, grow in holiness and love others. It is perhaps counter intuitive, but to produce greater godliness and holiness, we ought then to promote a greater participation in the love of God as revealed in the gospel... As in the way one cleans a water heater, the pure water is allowed to push out the impure water. So it is with love, God's loves pushes out self-love. Our marriage requires that we are experiencing God's love in order to love our spouse!

### **3. Each Partner acts as unto the Lord in marriage, not as unto their marriage partner:**

*Eph. 5:22 Wives, be subject to your husbands as you are to the Lord. 23 For the husband is*



*the head of the wife just as Christ is the head of the church, the body of which he is the Savior. 24 Just as the church is subject to Christ, so also wives ought to be, in everything, to their husbands.*

*Eph. 5:25 Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her, 26 in order to make her holy by cleansing her with the washing of water by the word, 27 so as to present the church to himself in splendor, without a spot or wrinkle or anything of the kind--yes, so that she may be holy and without blemish. 28 In the same way, husbands should love their wives as they do their own bodies. He who loves his wife loves himself. 29 For no one ever hates his own body, but he nourishes and tenderly cares for it, just as Christ does for the church, 30 because we are members of his body. 31 "For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two will become one flesh." 32 This is a great mystery, and I am applying it to Christ and the church. 33 Each of you, however, should love his wife as himself, and a wife should respect her husband.*

#### Obsevation:

No condition is put upon these commands that are relative to ones marriage partner. Wives respect husbands, not because of who the husband is, but because of God's design for men and women in relation together as a reflection of his relation to the church. Husbands love wives not because of who the wife is, but because of God's design for men and women in relation together as a reflection of his relation to the church. Clearly, then, God knows something about the way he made men and women so as to make these commands. As noted above, good marriages are the product of godly interactions between marriage partners. If a partner waits for the other to be somehow worthy of said respect and love, the opposite will be the effect. Respectful wives tend to make loving husbands, and loving husbands tend to produce respectful wives. Each partner must look to themselves so as to be found godly before God. The good news is that while you may never have a perfect marriage (humanly speaking) nothing about your spouse necessarily prevents you from being a godly spouse. Respect or love is both something you give out of your will, it is less about the way you feel and more about the way you act. While we can't turn on emotion like a faucet, we can turn on love and respect, if we understand these terms as acts of the will under Christ's control.

#### **4. Dare to believe in the power of the gospel and seek gospel oriented pastoral counseling!**

No need here to defend this advice, other than to say that God mediates his saving and healing presence through his church, which of course includes his word and sacrament, but also his shepherds in their office of oversight and counsel. (1Peter 5, Heb.13:7, 13) There IS a kind of counseling that seeks not to judge or condemn, but to help you experience God's grace for yourselves, so that you in turn can apply that grace to your marriage.

#### **5. Final General Exhortation from Scripture:**

*Proverbs 16:25, there is a way that seems right to a man, but in the end it leads to death.  
Proverbs 21:30, there is no wisdom, no insight, no plan that can succeed against the Lord.*

We live in a time where the "way that seems right to a person" is often divorce and separation in response to marriage problems. Perhaps it is this fundamental license that most needs to be challenged by those who follow after Christ. We must reaffirm that our ultimate purpose is not self-fulfillment, but rather to be re-made into the image of God so as to both glorify HIM and to enjoy HIM. Perhaps God intends your marriage to accomplish this-- and perhaps this will mean that your marriage is the means through which God will discipline you as one of his children in whom He loves. We must, if we are followers of Christ, be willing to submit to this plan of God, so as to be remade into his image by the lessons learned in our

difficult marriages. And on the way, perhaps we will also discover a plan for marriage that will succeed, at least as it makes us a more holy people-- more fit and able to glorify God and enjoy Him, both in this life and in the life to come. For it is true, that we will only ultimately know of the "success" of our lives here in this life by the value of life that awaits us with the Lord in heaven. Lest we forget, we are all Christ's bride, being made ready for Him and the glorious union that will be in the life to come. Might our marriages serve this end first, and only secondarily our more temporal ends.

## **II. Advice to the "innocent" party in determining what to do when it is believed they have grounds for divorce.**

- I. Read and discuss this paper (or one like it) that spells out the Biblical teachings concerning "Marriage and Divorce" with his/her Christian pastor.
- II. Ask marriage partner to do the same if a "Christian" and if not, to at least read the paper to understand where the Christian partner is "coming from."
- III. If supposed "guilty" partner is willing to a) confess the sin of adultery and/or desertion as defined biblically, b) if person is willing to get spiritual and/or medical and/or psychological help as a couple (and perhaps do what is necessary to stabilize the situation when there is a threat involved—e.g. temporary separation, etc), then the "innocent" party, albeit with "grounds" for divorce, may be encouraged all the same to proceed to walk by faith trusting that God can do the impossible and seek all and every means of help to see the marriage restored, trusting that eventually God can heal damaged emotions, etc.. However, it should be noted that once a person has Biblical grounds as per the scripture, it is the session's duty to rule in favor of the innocent party, even if the guilty party seems to be "repentant." See then # IV below...
- IV. If the "guilty" party is not willing to confess the sin(s) of desertion and/or adultery as defined by the Bible, then the "innocent" party should work with his/her church to discern whether or not there are Biblical grounds for divorce and proceed with legal protection, since divorce will protect the innocent parties rights as a Christian and person made in the image of God.

### Recommended Readings:

\*Dan Allender, Tremper Longman, *Intimate Allies*  
 Bryan Chappel, *Each for the Other*  
 Parrotti, *When Bad Things Happen to Good Marriages*  
 \*Larry Crabb, *The Marriage Builder*  
 Mack, *Strengthening Your Marriage*  
 Stanley, MacCain, Bryan, Trathen, *A Lasting Promise*  
 Mason, *The Mystery of Marriage*  
 Charlei Shedd, *Letters To Karen*  
 Markman, et. Al, *Fighting For Your Marriage*